



their own region's worst nuclear disaster, and you can feel the specific weight of that proximity in every design choice. This isn't American nuclear anxiety – the jaunty skulls and pin-up art of *Fallout*. This is something quieter, sicker, more personal. The game is technically rough in ways that have become legendary – a monument to bugs that somehow didn't kill it. It doesn't matter. The Zone takes hold and doesn't let go, and subsequent playthroughs only deepen the atmosphere. A cult classic that deserved its cult.

have all calcified into performance. The architecture is brutalist and water-damaged. The people are tired. Into this arrives the most singular protagonist in gaming: a police detective who has drunk himself into amnesia and must reconstruct both his identity and the circumstances of a murder using the competing voices of his own fragmented psyche.

There is almost no combat. There is more text than most novels. The writing is, without caveat, the finest in any game ever made – funny, devastating, politically serious, philosophically committed, and somehow genuinely warm beneath its layers of irony and ruin. *Disco Elysium* is the game that made other game writers feel slightly embarrassed about what they'd been doing. It takes the post-apocalyptic genre and turns the catastrophe inward, asking not what happens to a world after the end but what happens to a person. The answer, improbably, contains hope.

S.T.A.L.K.E.R.: SHADOW OF CHERNOBYL (2007)

The Zone. The word alone, for anyone who's played this game, summons a very specific texture of atmosphere: grey, wet, alive with anomalies, haunted by the whistling sound of invisible death. *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* uses the actual Chernobyl Exclusion Zone as its canvas, and what it builds

there is the most genuinely eerie open world ever conceived. Artifacts float. Packs of dogs hunt in formation. The grass looks like it hurts.

GSC Game World, a Ukrainian studio, was working in the shadow of

DEATH STRANDING (2019)

Hideo Kojima built a post-apocalyptic game about walking. About carrying packages carefully across treacherous terrain. About leaving ropes and ladders for strangers who will never

